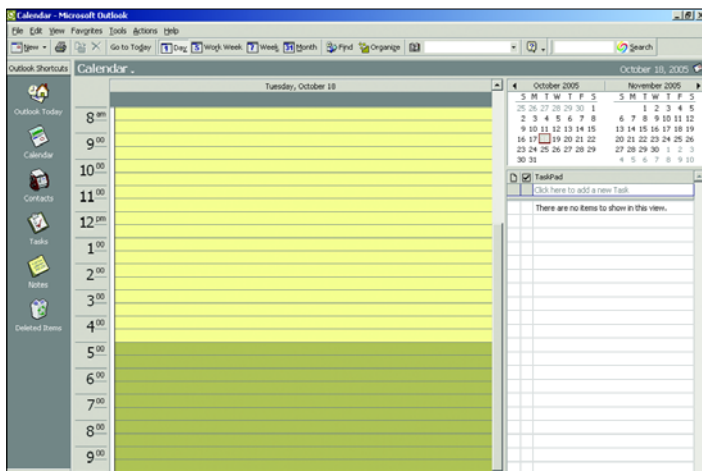




Outlook: The real Personal Information Manager

can also navigate to all entries beginning with a particular letter at just the click of a button!

Coming to the actual uses of a contact entry in Outlook, the question that needs to be asked is what all would you like to do. Sending e-mail, creating a reminder or scheduling a meeting is all just a click away.

Outlook allows users not merely to do everyday tasks, but also get interactive with e-mail. Take the example of voting on a subject: people need not be present physically, and can just click 'Yes' or 'No'—and a consensus can be had over e-mail. What's better is that this also ensures confidentiality and speed of response. The respondents could also add their notes or reasons for their vote.

Synchronising your contacts too, is easier, as is taking a backup when migrating computers or just clearing up disk space. It's time to change your Outlook, eh?

Mobile PIM

If you happen to be an on-the-go professional who collects more phone numbers and visiting cards than you can remember, there are ways for you to organise your innumerable contacts.

With the changing times, we're used to noting down new phone numbers directly on our phones or PDAs. Often, we forget to include other vital information such as the company name, or why we have that number in the first place! It's good practice to include such info, because no amount of automation or technology can help you with information that it does not know!



Know Outlook Better

- ❑ You can use MS Word as the default text editor in Outlook.
- ❑ You can include a rich text signature that features characters in bold, italics, and different font sizes in Outlook.
- ❑ Your Task List can also be shown on the Schedule Sheet and e-mailed as an assignment.
- ❑ You can view and print out your Schedule Sheet in more ways than one to ensure you have an optimised view of your activities.
- ❑ Colour coding on the calendar allows you to identify the task (Personal, Business, Birthday) at a glance. You can even share this with your team or assistant and mark whether you will be out of office or not.



Essential PIM: Would you like to import all Outlook info?



Nicely laid out parts of the Essential PIM

If you are using a PDA phone (or even a smartphone), it is always recommended that you regularly back up all your phone data via Bluetooth, IR or a data cable. Almost all phones (and corresponding sync software) are capable of detecting changes to even a single field in data that is already present as backup. This ensures that you don't have to worry about updated or changed contacts not being backed up.

Outlook And Mobile?

Now here's the interesting part. The data you already have in your Outlook, and data you've backed up from your phone, can work together and make your information management even more robust. How?

There are problems in synchronising your handheld directly with Outlook, but there is a way around this. Better still, this could be a one-time operation from Outlook by exporting your contacts as a CSV (Comma Separated Values) file. In the case of Nokia PC Suite, you can then export this file and have all your contacts sync with your handheld.

For devices by other manufacturers, the same may not hold true, and you may have to manually import (copy) contacts before synchronising. But hey, it's just once, and then, they're all in one place!

Third-Party PIMs

Freeware rules the world. Well, almost. So it's not surprising that there are freeware to counter the PIM problem as well. Another reason for using freeware is that it's legal, and you won't be using pirated versions of Outlook.